

The Accuracy and Biases of the Mexican Historical Film: The Involvement of the Second French
Intervention Between 1861 - 1867

Victor J. Barajas

Professor Alyssa G. Sepinwall

HIST 460

December 11, 2024

“Narratives beat reality,” a comment by Juan Miguel Zunzunegui, a Mexican historian, conference, and writer who dedicates his work to revealing Mexico’s historiography. A noble work for historians who research historical evidence through archives to find out the truth of Mexican history, which is either narrated or portrays inaccurate information through the media. For instance, some Mexican historical films depict a narration of the past, intending to nourish and enhance the viewer’s Mexican nationality while silencing a group of people’s history who are considered either the enemy of the state or are not considered a significant group that participates within the Mexican history. Some of the best examples of Mexican historical films that follow the historicity’s narration are the documentary *Patria*, directed by Matias Gueilburt, and the movie *Cinco de Mayo: La Batalla*, directed by Rafa Lara, showing the historical events of the second French intervention in Mexico between 1861 and 1867. While both films do attempt to reveal the actual history of the past, they only reveal one side of the coin’s historical events that decide not to reveal a different perspective, which sometimes is either influenced or invested by the Mexican government to produce this film. For this purpose, I will be combining the theories of Michel-Rolph Trouillot, Robert Ronestone, and Alyssa G. Sepinwall with the analysis of two historical films of the Mexican and French conflict while revealing historians’ books and journals that discuss this event. In doing so, I will also reveal how these two films were able to show visual historical interpretation, but limited information compared to scholar’s work.

The treatment of the historical film of the second French intervention in Mexico is accurate in many respects but also reflects partial perspectives. In the case of the documentary film *Patria*, directed by Matias Geilburt, it unveils the historical events between 1854 and 1867, which built up the Mexican nationality, sovereignty, and identity through the internal and

external conflict that established Mexico as a republic. The main external conflict that is narrated during this period is the involvement of the French Empire, ruled by Napoleon III, who decided to expand his influence over the Americas, starting with Mexico with the excuse of recovering the Mexican debt they owed. Meanwhile, the whole plan was to establish a satellite-state monarchy in Mexico, which was petitioned by the Mexican conservatives. In contrast, the Mexican Republic resisted the French army until their withdrawal in 1867. Indeed, this documentary was inspired by the trilogy book *Patria*, published and narrated by Paco Ignacio Taibo II, who is a Mexican journalist, novelist, political activist, and director of the *Fondo de Cultura Economica* (FCE). In this film, he shows his arguments and explains the historical events of the second French intervention in Mexico as he speaks with other specialists and arrives at the historical location where the French and the Mexican Republic would fight against each other.

Knowing this, Gueilburt and Taibo does a great job of showing the documentary with accurate information on the Mexican history that involved the second French intervention. For example, the documentary revealed the mindset of Ferdinand Latrille, Count of Lorençez, regarding the French superiority over the Mexicans “in race, organization, morality, and elevated sentiments,” having a mindset that he could defeat the Mexican liberals only with 6,000 troops.¹ Indeed, this clip of the documentary can be linked with the historical accuracy that Arturo Aguilar Ochoa presented in his article, revealing the exact words of Latrille before the start of the Battle of Puebla.² Another accurate example of the film is with Taibo’s interview with Mexican economist, Guillermo Fernandez, where he reveals the foreign debts that Mexico owed

¹ Gueilburt, *Patria*, (33:07 – 33:52).

² Galeana, *El Imperio Napoleónico*, 241.

as a result of its internal wars with the total of 80 - 85 million MXN pesos, especially to Great Britain, Spain, and France.³ This information is reflected more in the financial crisis that President Benito Juarez saw after the Reform War, in which he took drastic action to suspend all foreign debt for two years to strengthen its fiscal position in its northern states and to avoid future revolts.⁴ In viewing these examples, Gueilburt and Taibo did an excellent job of establishing historical accuracy within the documentary by revealing the historicity with facts.

On the other hand, *Patria* only reveals biased information on the perspective of the Liberal campaign compared to the Conservatives. Once the French army, led by General Elie-Frederic Forey, was able to capture Puebla and Mexico City, Napoleon III offered the Mexican Crown to Archduke Maximilian of Habsburg, together with his wife Charlotte of Belgium, which they later arrived in Veracruz in 1864. Despite presenting the information on their arrival to Mexico, Gueilburt and Taibo are not dedicated to informing the viewers on what projects Maximilian worked on once living in Chapultepec Castle in Mexico City. Instead, Taibo shows his criticism of the French oligarchy and Maximilian's lifestyle inside the castle, showing more of a bias that does not put much seriousness on Maximilian.⁵ There is another clip where Taibo also criticizes both the Mexican Conservatives for also offering the Crown of Mexico to Maximilian while showing his bias side on the form of monarch's governing a nation.⁶ Both of these examples exposed the inclination that Gueilburt and Taibo had toward the Mexican Republic instead of displaying accurate information on both Maximilian's political decision and the development of the Second Mexican Empire.

³ Gueilburt, *Patria*, (28:07 – 29:40).

⁴ Hamnett, *A Concise History of Mexico*, 162 – 163.

⁵ Gueilburt, *Patria*, (1:00:18 – 1:03:41).

⁶ Gueilburt, *Patria*, (52:40 – 58:00).

Meanwhile, historians offer more information through academic journals on the form of how Maximilian would govern over the Second Mexican Empire. For instance, William H. Beezley would argue that once Maximilian arrived in Mexico City as the new Emperor of the newly installed monarchy, he would start to pass laws and ratify the existing Liberal Reform that had already been present since the Reform War, alienating himself from the Mexican Conservatives and the Catholic Church for not eliminating the reform laws.⁷ In addition, Maximilian rule over the state of Sonora led him to administrate and establish municipalities and administration that would help them while dividing the state into three divisions that is Sonora, Alamos, and Arizona.⁸ Noticing that different historians give small details on how Maximilian reigned over Mexico, it reveals that both Gueilburt and Taibo's goal objective within the documentary was to increase Mexican nationalism while at least presenting authentic historical facts about the Mexican side of history.

Furthermore, Taibo's biases against Napoleon III's ambition over Mexico only reveal some of the problems that the Second French Empire faced that persuaded him to withdraw his troops from Mexico. To illustrate, Taibo explains that the French army, led by General Forey, would pursue the Mexican Liberal government by heading north of the country, which faced some Mexican resistance in the process. According to Taibo, the lack of motivation among the French troops spent around 300 million MXN pesos, and because of the rising threat of Prussia on France's border, Napoleon gave up his ambition over Mexico, leaving Maximilian behind.⁹ While this is an accurate reason why Napoleon III decided to withdraw his troops from Mexico, the United States was also influenced by pressuring France to stop expanding its influence over

⁷ Beezley, *México --- The Essentials*, 24 – 25.

⁸ Galeana, *El Imperio Napoleónico*, 297 – 298.

⁹ Gueilburt, *Patria*, (1:04:58 – 1:08:41).

the Americas, especially with Mexico. Considering that by 1867, the United States had defeated the Confederate States in its Civil War, it could finally threaten France by using the Monroe Doctrine, supporting the Mexican Liberals from the north to combat the French army.

Ironically, Taibo's narration of his trilogy book, *Patria*, reveals a specific narration on how Mexican nationalism is forged through the victories and defeat against Napoleon III's ambition over North America. As you can see, in Taibo's interview with Jesus Lopez, he explained that the purpose of the book was to reveal the history of Mexico between 1854 and 1867, where he could reveal the small histories of both the Conservatives and Liberals, including the French and Maximilian intervention in Mexico.¹⁰ Yet, just like how we were able to see Taibo's bias by labeling the Mexican Conservatives as traitors of the nation, he does not dedicate the documentary to explaining much information on the side of French history in Mexico, silencing them in the process. Especially where the French army, led by General Forey, would be instructed to map out the rest of Mexico's geographical points to accurately locate cities and dominate them for the Second Mexican Empire.¹¹ Despite historical evidence present, Gueilburt and Taibo choose to silence the French troop's history from participating in the intervention in Mexico.

Another historical film involving the second French intervention in Mexico, *Cinco de Mayo: La Batalla*, also has strengths and weaknesses, as it gives more detail, but still has a distorted perspective. For instance, at the beginning of the film, Lara reveals a scene of the dialogue between Napoleon III and General Latrille on the missions to intervene in Mexico to establish a monarchy that the Mexican Conservatives requested help. In it, Lara shows a plan

¹⁰ López, *Hablamos de Patria*, (00:00 – 11:15).

¹¹ Puyo, *The French Military confront Mexico's Geography*, 142 – 148.

that the Mexican monarchy is to form an alliance with the Confederate States and establish a division between the United States and the Confederate States, all under General Latrille's mission in Mexico.¹² If we are to compare with actual history, Napoleon III's ambition over Mexico shows that his ultimate goal in establishing a monarchy in Mexico was to destabilize the United States by maintaining its division while turning the Second Mexican Empire into a powerful region in North America.¹³ That being the case, Lara also manages to introduce historical accuracy within his film, where he desires to inform the Mexican historicity through.

However, the historical film of *Cinco de Mayo* is mixed with a few fictional characters that participate in past events, mixing with cinematic drama. For example, the protagonist of Lara's movie presents Juan Osorno, together with Citlali, as individuals who participate in the early stage of the second French intervention in Mexico, where both characters wander around as they encounter the French army.¹⁴ When witnessing the characters in the film, we can see that it involves drama and romantic connections between the two individuals, which is used to entertain the audience through novels between historical events. Despite this, Juan and Citlali would become the Mexican icon of both a soldier and a civilian in participating in defending Puebla from General Latrille's troops.

Moreover, *Cinco de Mayo* is produced to promote Mexican nationalism and identity as a sovereign and independent nation-state from the second French intervention. According to Lara's speech at the conference at the Seattle Latino Film Festival (SLFF) in 2014, the state government of Puebla contacted him and five different movie directors to produce a historical film that would

¹² Lara, *Cinco de Mayo*, (03:92 – 5:54).

¹³ Kelley, *The North American Crisis*, 337 – 339.

¹⁴ Lara, *Cinco de Mayo*, (45:00 – 57:19).

involve the Battle of Puebla for the 150th anniversary of Cinco de Mayo.¹⁵ Once Lara gave his proposal for the film, the state government decided to fund him enough money to sufficiently complete and publish the film, which he was chosen because he wanted to present small details of the Battle of Puebla. This would meet the expectation of showing the process and the development of the historical conflict between Mexico and France.

In addition, the historical film of *Cinco de Mayo* disregards showing only the perspective of Liberal Mexicans and only explains a few detailed information about the historical events before and after the Battle of Puebla. Such as the Mexican Liberal soldiers executing Mexican Conservative troops and generals through a firing squad at the beginning of the film.¹⁶ While this clip only shows the conclusion of the Reform War, it does not give enough historical background for the audience to understand the conflict between Liberals and Conservatives, which is essential to understand the reason why the Conservatives decided to seek Napoleon III's aid to establish a Mexican monarchy after being defeated by President Benito Juarez and his administration. Besides, once the Battle of Puebla concluded with General Latrille's loss, Lara chose to offer a small summary of the historical events that happened after Cinco de Mayo.¹⁷ Yet, by using this method of explaining the historical events after the Battle of Puebla, the information provided seems to lean toward what happens after the battle and does not offer a real historical significance to know exactly what's going on.

Both historical films were able to produce accurate information about the Mexican historical side with the help of government agencies and streaming funds, allowing the historical films to

¹⁵ Bustillos, *SLFF Q + A's: Rafa Lara on Filming Cinco de Mayo*, (00:00 – 1:40).

¹⁶ Lara, *Cinco de Mayo*, (02:40 – 3:32).

¹⁷ Lara, *Cinco de Mayo*, (1:58:00 – 1:59:21).

be shown in public in the process.¹⁸ Yet it does not reveal the silenced history of the Mexican noble family that at least one family member got involved with Maximilian of Habsburg. To understand this, Mexico gained its independence with the help of Agustin de Iturbide by establishing the Mexican Empire in 1821, where he would become the first Mexican Emperor of the House of Iturbide. However, his empire and his legacy would not last since Mexico later became a republic a year after gaining independence from Spain, while the Iturbide family exiled the country to Europe and then to the United States, where Agustin de Iturbide would be considered a traitor to the fatherland and then be executed by the Mexican troops immediately once he was spotted.¹⁹ Despite the execution of Agustin de Iturbide by the Mexican government, the Iturbide family maintained its identity as a noble and royal family of the House of Iturbide, where Maximilian of Habsburg, later known as the Emperor of the Second Mexican Empire, adopted one of Agustin's grandson, Agustin Jose de Iturbide y Green. The Purpose of Maximilian adopting 2-year-old Agustin de Iturbide y Green had a political purpose: once Maximilian and Charlotte passed away, he would become the new heir to the Crown of Mexico.²⁰

While Maximilian kept Agustin de Iturbide y Green as his child, he wouldn't last long to return him to his family before the Mexican Liberals would capture and execute Maximilian in the state of Queretaro. Indeed, Agustin de Iturbide y Green was only a child at that time, who is of Mexican nobility and the son of an American citizen, yet he was the Prince of the House of Iturbide, which had significance in the Mexican political system during the second French intervention in Mexico, which still exists to this day. The fact that despite the historical evidence

¹⁸ Sepinwall, *Slave Revolt on Screen*, 113.

¹⁹ Iturbide, *The Crown Prince of Georgetown*, 10 - 17

²⁰ Blasio, *Maximilian, Emperor of Mexico*, 44.

present, none of the films reveals the existence of the Iturbide family, silencing their past as if they stopped existing since the death of Agustín de Iturbide.²¹ In doing so, both historical films create a different form of narrative that takes away the context of Mexican history regarding the decision of Maximilian of Habsburg to attempt to secure the Second Mexican Empire by having an adoptive son as the heir to the Crown of Mexico.

Other victims of their past silenced by both historical films are the French citizens' point of view, which does not reveal their thoughts on what the French people reflect about the second French intervention in Mexico. One of the forms that we can reveal the French citizens' thoughts on the second intervention in Mexico is through media like newspapers. Indeed, the information that was provided by the French newspaper was filled with propaganda that Napoleon III shared to reveal his subjects to accept the justification to intervene in Mexico while censoring some information that would persuade the French people to protest the intervention.²² This would cause the French people to have an interest in learning more about Mexican history and its geography by traveling to the historical sites that Mexico has to offer during the intervention. However, the interest would soon collapse once the newspaper published more information about the threat of Prussia on their border.

Another form that the French people would reveal their thoughts on the second intervention in Mexico is through the French troops' monographs while mapping out the topography of Mexico. As you can see, some French units wrote memoirs that recorded the demographics of the Mexican population that they occupied in the process while also writing letters that would reveal their honest thoughts that their intervention in Mexico was doing "more damage than good

²¹ Rosenstone, *Visions of the Past*, 9.

²² Galeana, *El Imperio Napoleónico*, 227 – 244.

to this country.”²³ These types of letters would impact the morality and the formation that the French units would attempt to succeed in their missions to defeat the Mexican republic, deteriorating their morality as they advanced to northern Mexico. At the same time, just like General Latrille, some French troops, especially Napoleon III, would view this expansion of French influence over Mexico as a necessary form of establishing a stable government that had French influence, to assimilate the Mexican people.²⁴ Indeed, this historical evidence has not been revealed in either of the two historical films, which silences the thoughts of the French people and unit troops on whether to support the intervention or not.

As a result, combining the theories of Michel-Rolph Trouillot, Robert Ronestone, and Alyssa Sepinwall with the analysis of the historical film of the Mexican and French conflict reveals how these two films were able to show visual historical interpretation, but limited information compared to scholarly work. This is a necessary form of analysis to see whether the historical films of Mexican history were indeed sharing the accuracy of historical events during the second French intervention in Mexico or only aimed to share specific information to nourish and enhance Mexican nationalism. Of course, both historical films, *Patria* and *Cinco de Mayo: La Batalla*, aimed their goal to share with their viewers the correct information that was provided by historians. Yet, by not offering any historical evidence from the specific group, the directors and narrator unknowingly silenced a specific group’s past by never mentioning their participation and involvement in history. This is the main reason why we as historians must dedicate ourselves to research and revealing the hidden past that media tend to silence and instead create a different

²³ Puyo, *The French Military confront Mexico’s Geography*, 148 - 150.

²⁴ Trouillot, *Silencing the Past*, 76.

narrative that is not historical. Otherwise, not revealing the silenced history of individuals from media will only lead narratives to truly beat reality.

Bibliography

- Blasio, Jose Luis. *Maximilian, Emperor of Mexico*. Edited by Robert Hammond Murray. New Haven: Yale University Press, 1934.
- Bustillos, Gisella. 2014. "SLFF Q+A's: Rafa Lara on Filming Cinco de Mayo." *SLFF TV*. April 15. Accessed November 13, 2024.
<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=KghrMHRizq4&t=10s>
- Beezley, William H. "Politics: Independence to the Present." Chap 2. in *Mexico – The Essentials*. New York: Oxford University Press, 2016.
- Escoto, Norma Z. *La defensa de la Republica y la soberanía nacional. El Ejercito de Oriente, 1864 – 1867*. Mexico City: Metropolitan Autonomous University, 2015.
- Galeana, Patricia. *El Imperio Napoleónico y la Monarquía en México*. Mexico City: Senate of the Republic, 2012.
- Gueilburt, Matias. *Patria*. 2019; Mexico City: Doc & Films Production Inc. Netflix.
- Hamnett, Brian R. "Destabilization and fragmentation, 1770 – 1867." Chap. 5 in *A Concise History of Mexico*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2006.
- Hamnett, Brian R. "Mexican Conservatives, Clericals, and Soldiers: the 'Traitor' Tomas Mejia through Reform and Empire, 1855 – 1867." *Bulletin of Latin American Research* 20, no. 2 (2001): 187 – 209. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/3339608>
- Iturbide, Louise Kearney de. "The Crown Prince of Georgetown: The Life of Agustin de Iturbide y Green, Heir to the Mexican Throne (1863 -1925)." Edited by Stewart Addington Saint-David. *Academia.edu*. 2022.
https://www.academia.edu/88608588/BOOK_The_Crown_Prince_of_Georgetown_The_Life_of_Agustin_de_Iturbide_Heir_to_the_Mexican_Throne_1863_1925_

Kelly, Patrick J. *The North American Crisis of the 1860s*. Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2012.

Lara, Rafa. *Cinco de Mayo: La Batalla*. 2013; Santa Mónica, CA: Pantaleón. Televisa. Lionsgate.

López, Jesús. 2021. “Hablamos de Patria, La Trilogía de Paco Ignacio Taibo II.” *Tu Profe de RI*. September 16. Accessed November 12, 2024.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Sg5tpW0Mt9o>

Puyo, Jean-Yves. *The French Military confront Mexico's Geography: the Expedition of 1862 – 67*. Austin: University of Texas Press, 2010.

Rosenstone, Robert A. *Vision of the Past: The Challenge of Film to Our Idea of History*. Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2001.

Sepinwall, Alyssa G. *Slave Revolt on Screen: The Haitian Revolution in Film and Video Games*. Jackson: University Press of Mississippi, 2021.

Trouillot, Michel-R. *Silencing the Past: Power and the Production of History*, Boston: Beacon Press, 1995.